This was also a period when Tantric Buddhism became influential in eastern India and was transmitted to Tibet. During the Mongol Yuan dynasty (1279–1368 CE) in China, Tibetan Buddhism would make inroads into China, with Tibetan lamas becoming preceptors of the Mongol rulers, as will be narrated in greater detail in Chapters 10 and 11.

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China remained the dominant sea power during the Song, Yuan and early Ming periods, a period spanning the first four centuries of the second millennium. Its seagoing vessels were technologically the most advanced of the time in the world. However, when the Ming emperor Xuan De decided to dispense with long-distance voyages altogether in 1435 CE , dismantle the shipyards and even destroy the marine charts and records compiled during the seven naval expeditions undertaken by Admiral Zheng He, China reverted to being a land power for the next 500 years. When the Japanese and Western navies launched repeated assaults on the Qing empire in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, China found itself defenceless. The century of humiliation that the Chinese speak about was the result mainly of this long neglect of its maritime frontiers.

In the next chapter we will consider Zheng He’s voyages in some detail. His naval expeditions during the early part of the Ming dynasty (1368–1644), undertaken in giant ships constructed in the Nanjing shipyards, took him to South-East Asia, the Indian subcontinent, the Gulf and eastern Africa, and influenced China’s view of the world. The Malabar kingdoms played an important role as staging posts for these voyages, and one of the mariners, Ma Huan, who accompanied Zheng He on some of the voyages, has left interesting accounts of these kingdoms and of India in general. These will add to our understanding of how Chinese perceptions of India evolved over the first half of the second millennium.

One such collection of Song celadon is at the private Jalan Museum in Patna, which also has a fine collection of Han dynasty jade.

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